

ELECTORAL CAMPAIGNS AND VOTER BEHAVIOR: A SYSTEMATIC LITERATURE REVIEW AND AGENDA FOR FUTURE RESEARCH

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Abstract

This systematic review applies the Theory-Context-Method (TCM) framework to 46 peer-reviewed studies published from 1996 to 2024, providing an integrated assessment of how theoretical models, empirical settings, and research designs interact across diverse electoral landscapes. The review identifies seven prominent theoretical lenses—agenda-setting and priming, populist communication, negative campaigning, affective intelligence, poll/bandwagon effects, gendered mediation, and digital information processing—that consistently shape campaign outcomes. Methodologically, studies rely heavily on content–survey linkage in rich-media contexts, with a growing but uneven adoption of digital trace methods, biometric indicators, and field experiments. Notably, underexplored domains remain, including multilingual and diasporic electorates, institutions like open-list voting and compulsory participation, and digital environments influenced by algorithmic gatekeeping. By synthesizing theory, context, and method, this review presents a refined research agenda for the future, encouraging model-building that incorporates institutional variation, examines hybrid media venues, and integrates multimodal evidence. Practically, the findings inform more context-aware campaign strategies, smarter regulation of digital ads, and enhanced transparency in media coverage and polling practices.

Keywords: Electoral Campaigns, Political Campaigns, Voter Behavior, Systematic Literature Review (SLR), TCM Framework

Gel Codes: D70, D72, D83

1. Introduction

Electoral campaigns have a significant influence on voter behavior and preferences (O’Cass & Pecotich, 2005). It is essential to acknowledge that these campaigns also impact undecided voters during the electoral process (Belcastro et al., 2022). Thus, election campaigns can be viewed as valuable sources of information that aid voters in making informed decisions (O’Cass, 2002). Before the advent of advanced mass communication technologies, personal interactions — such as shaking hands, extensive travel, and tailored programs — were crucial to electoral campaigns (Eldersveld, 1956). Additionally, while candidates’ communication efforts positively influence their vote counts, the efforts made by their opponents detract from overall support (Chapman & Palda, 1984). Today, the relationship between electoral campaigns and voter behavior has undergone significant evolution. For instance, when voters align with the issues that candidates prioritize during election campaigns, their likelihood of supporting those candidates increases (Abbe et al., 2003). This occurs because voters gather subjective insights from political campaigning (O’Cass & Pecotich, 2005). Moreover, electoral campaigns facilitate not only direct interactions with voters but also foster online participation and large-scale public opinion polling through social media platforms (Wulf et al., 2013; Hong & Nadler, 2015). Political campaigns can influence individuals who hold opposing views to alter their voting intentions, thereby minimizing conflict (Mancosu, 2019). Additionally, Schmitt-Beck and Partheymüller (2016) found that shared political affiliations or voting for the same party during the campaign can increase the likelihood of continued support for that party following the elections. One of the tools that politicians use to influence voters is political campaigns (Palazzolo & Theriault, 1996). Although the primary goal of political campaigns seems to be to persuade voters, on the other hand, it also serves to identify and exclude others with different interests (Potters et al., 1997). Election campaigns are important for the reward of the election on the one hand and reflect the policies of those presented through election promises on the other hand (Guo, 2020). Election promises to affect the trustworthiness of politicians depending on the politicians’ ability to fulfill them. (Carson et al., 2019). In addition, election promises are used by politicians to influence voters’ decisions. (Corazzini et al., 2014; Werner, 2019). Social networks and social media further strengthen the links between voter performance and election campaigns (Alhassan, 2018). Finally, political campaigns increase understanding, awareness and further presentation of elections. (Binder et al., 2015).

The relationship between election campaigns and voter behavior can be explained in a variety of contexts by a range of theories and methodological approaches. This hinders the process of developing a research agenda for future studies. Against this background, the current systematic study focuses five main questions:

RQ1: How is the overview of the existing literature on the subject of study?

RQ2: Which theories underpin the relationship between electoral campaigns and voter behavior?

RQ3: In which contexts have the current studies been conducted?

RQ4: What methods have been employed in the existing literature to explain the study subject?

RQ5: What are future research avenues regarding theories, contexts, and methods?

This systematic review addresses general questions within the Theory-Context-Method (TCM) framework proposed by Paul et al. (2017). In this context, the study provides an in-depth look at the literature on the relationship between voter behavior and election campaigns and critically evaluates the existing literature. It is aimed at accelerating academic research on the subject. In addition, it provides a practical benefit for those planning and running a political campaign.

2. Research Method

2.1. Systematic Review

A type of secondary research, systematic review uses reproducible techniques to identify, evaluate, and synthesize information about specific research questions. (Paul & Criado, 2020). Its main objectives include providing suggestions for future research, outlining the current status, and identifying inconsistencies and gaps in the current body of knowledge. (Kocaman & Coşgun, 2024). Achieving this requires a rigorous methodological approach, as well as following specific steps and making definitive decisions. (Sauer & Seuring, 2023). It is up to you to provide an accurate summary of the relevant literature and assess the overall impact on the study population. Consequently, an overview can be developed with sufficient documentation on a specific study subject.

Meta-analytical, theory-based, method-based, and domain-based reviews are the four primary categories into which systematic reviews fall (Paul & Criado, 2020). Each type employs a unique strategy and fulfills a certain function. Meta-analytical reviews use statistical techniques to assess previous empirical research on a particular subject (Öztürk et al., 2024). Theory-based reviews look at how a certain theory has affected a field. Method-based reviews examine how particular approaches are used in a particular field of study. A domain-based review focuses on a specific topic area within a specific field and aims to compile, evaluate, and synthesize existing knowledge in that field. This can be accomplished through five different methods: (1) structured reviews, which focus on widely used theories, constructs, contexts, and methods (Hao et al., 2020); (2) framework-based reviews, which use an existing framework or an independently developed framework (Paul & Benito, 2018); (3) bibliometric reviews that analyze trends and statistics (Donthu et al., 2020); (4) hybrid reviews that combine principles from two or more types of reviews (Kumar et al., 2020); and (5) theory-developing reviews that offer new theories, hypotheses, and propositions (Paul & Mas, 2020). To ascertain the existing understanding, how this understanding is attained, and where future research should concentrate within the study's context, this study employs a domain-based systematic review using a framework-based methodology. This method is ideal for filling the gap since it arranges frameworks, which facilitates the systematic integration of earlier research (Paul & Criado, 2020).

2.2. Selection of the Framework

To guarantee a systematic review's quality, relevance, and impact, the content must be arranged methodically. By efficiently arranging the information, this structure distinguishes the review from others (Siddaway et al., 2019). Because of its structure, readers can easily access certain facts in the document and know where to go for pertinent material (Paul & Criado, 2020). The TCM (Theory-Context-Method) framework, which is used in this review study, carefully arranges the essential elements of earlier research among different frameworks for creating systematic reviews. Methods provide the empirical evidence employed, contexts describe the conditions being examined, and theories express the guiding perspectives of researchers. Future researchers can use this methodology to reproduce or find new discoveries across different frameworks for creating systematic reviews. (Paul et al., 2017).

2.3. Protocol

One of the most important steps in the systematic review process is developing a reporting protocol. By offering careful process planning and documentation, this contributes to the integrity and transparency of the study. Because it is the norm for reporting systematic reviews, the PRISMA protocol (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses) was used to help pick publications on the relationship between election campaigns and voter behavior.

Identification, screening, eligibility, and inclusion are the four main phases of the protocol. As seen in Figure 1, these phases offer a methodical framework for the review process, which is further described in the parts that follow, based on observations made by Ter Huurne et al. (2017).

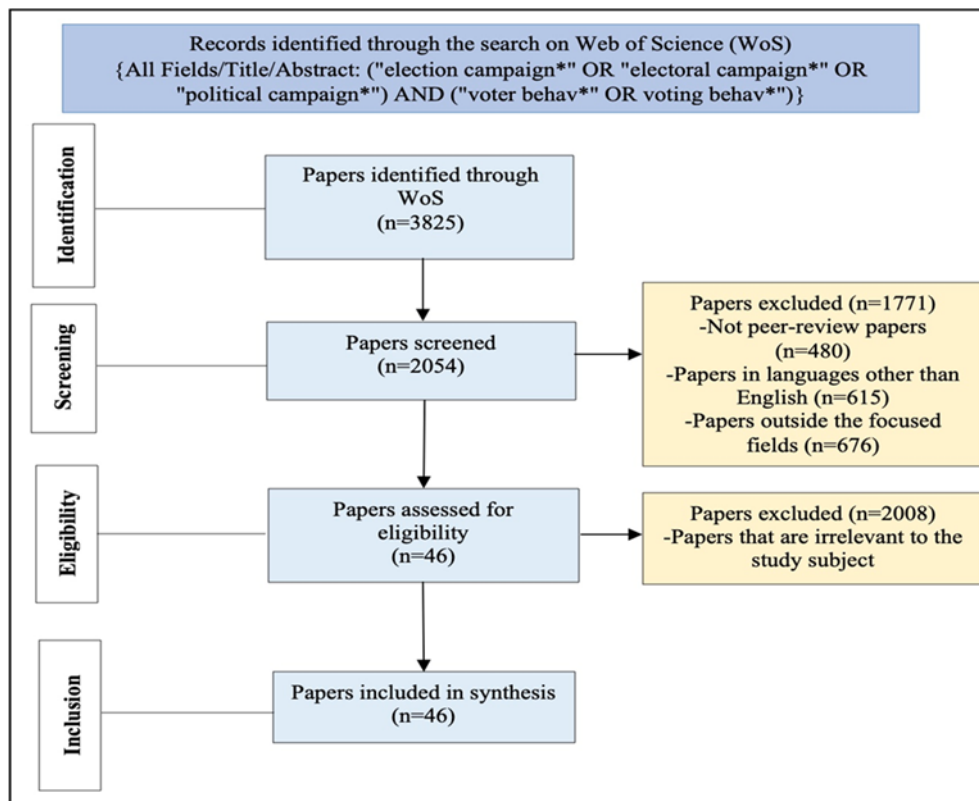


Figure 1. Flow Diagram of Article Selection Employing the PRISMA Protocol Source: Author's own drawing.

2.4. Identification

For the identification stage, search keywords, source quality and search time were determined as three criteria used in classifying. With an emphasis on the connection between electoral campaigns and voter behavior, the database search's keywords ((“election campaign*” OR “electoral campaign*” OR “political campaign*”) AND (“voter behav*” OR voting behav*)) were carefully chosen to guarantee thoroughness. High-quality sources were ensured by using the Web of Science (WoS) to collect the data. Because WoS is the most comprehensive source of citation data globally, covers a wide range of English-language publications since 1990, is more effective for searching and analyzing open access publications, spans multiple knowledge domains, and gives institutional members access to publications, we chose to use it over other databases like Scopus, EBSCO, or Google Scholar. The search was limited to articles published between 1996 and 2024, focusing on recent and past publications to reflect current developments better and provide a solid foundation for future research. This stage yielded a total of 3825 articles.

2.5. Screening

Our review only included journal articles, excluding 480 non-journal publications, such as book chapters, theses, technical notes, and conference papers. Only journal articles were considered because they're credible and reliable, thanks to the rigorous peer review conducted by experts in the field (Öztürk et al., 2024). As the language of science, English-language literature is typically advised to be the primary focus (Paul & Criado, 2020). 615 papers that were written in languages other than English were thus disqualified. Additionally, in order to guarantee that our selection criteria matched the goals of the study, the study fields were restricted to Political Science, Communication, Business,

and Management. Consequently, 676 papers from different domains were not included in the evaluation process. After a rigorous screening procedure, 2054 papers were assessed for eligibility.

2.6. Eligibility

To exclude irrelevant articles resulting from erroneous matches, researchers must manually check the article previews (titles, abstracts, and keywords) following automated filtering (Sauer & Seuring, 2023). In order to prioritize unique contributions and weed out replication studies, a thorough manual examination of 2054 full-text papers were carried out during the eligibility stage. Each article's relevance was assessed by looking at its abstract, keywords, and title. After 2008 articles were eliminated because of this approach, 46 articles that concentrate on the connection between election campaigns and voter behavior remained.

2.7. Inclusion

Every article that made the short list was carefully examined to guarantee its validity and thoroughness before being included. This exacting procedure was used as a quality control method to find and fix any possible mistakes or omissions in the selecting process. Consequently, 46 articles were selected for the systematic review's synthesis.

3. General Overview

3.1. Dispersion Across Years

Examining the periods of heightened or diminished scholarly activity provides valuable insight into how research agendas are influenced by external factors such as technological change, major events, and shifts in the media landscape. Viewed through this temporal perspective, we can discern whether the field responds to immediate stimuli or progresses in a more cumulative manner. (see Figure 2)

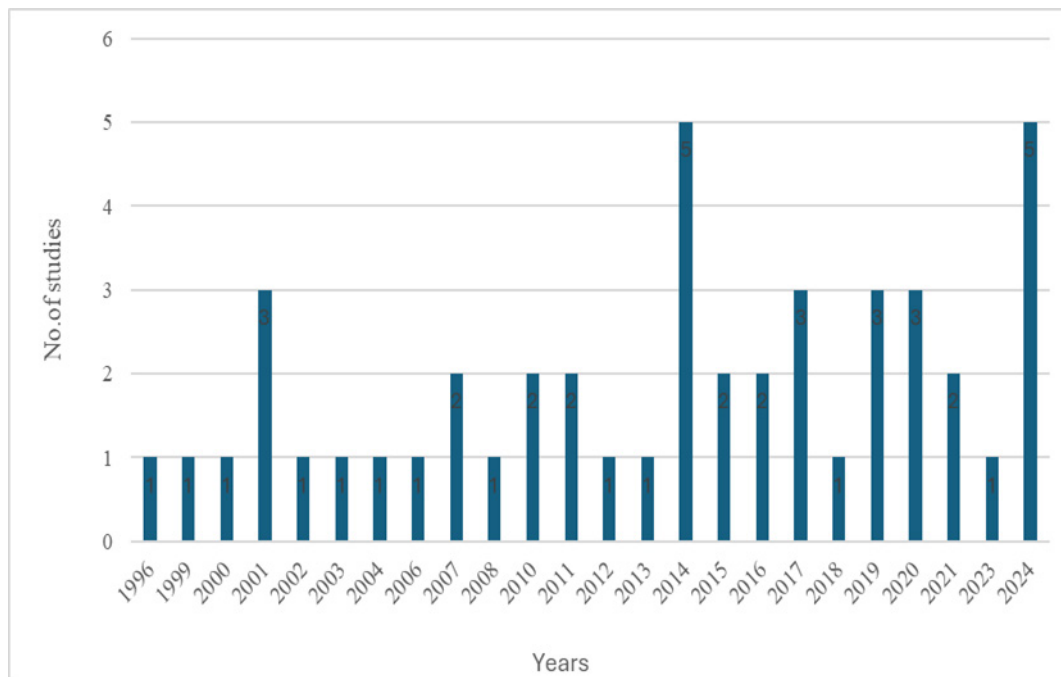


Figure 2. Dispersion of Studies Across Years. Source: Author's own drawing.

Kinsey and Chaffee’s (1996) study of presidential approval during the Gulf War is seen as the beginning of the relevant literature on the relationship between voter behavior and the media coverage dynamics (Kinsey & Chaffee, 1996). Building on this, Erikson and Wlezien’s (1999) influential time-series study demonstrated how public opinion fluctuates systematically throughout electoral cycles, instigating decades of bandwagon-effect research (Erikson & Wlezien, 1999). Subsequent years saw a relatively stable but modest publishing rhythm, including Domke, Shah, and Wackman’s (2000) moral framing exploration and Kleinnijenhuis et al.’s (2001) comparative media study in Germany and the Netherlands. A turning point emerged in 2014 when Bos and Brants (2014) executed a longitudinal content analysis of populist rhetoric, Elmelund-Præstekær and Svensson (2014) mapped Danish negativity cycles, and Hansen and Pedersen (2014) demonstrated that campaigns elevate voter efficacy through multi-method approaches. Post-COVID, the field surged again in 2024 with new work on AI-driven ad tailoring, poll credibility, and data-informed regulation—highlighting that research momentum aligns with technological and regulatory disruptions rather than accruing steadily.

3.2. Most Productive Publication Outlets

Examining the dominant publication venues provides a window into disciplinary norms, peer networks, and the visibility of key findings. It highlights which academic communities are shaping the discourse and where significant work is published. (see Table 1)

Rank	Journal	Number of articles in dataset	Illustrative scope
1	<i>Political Communication</i>	10	International, theory-driven hub for politics/communication research
2	<i>European Journal of Communication</i>	8	Wide remit on European and global media studies
3	<i>International Journal of Press/Politics</i>	7	Interdisciplinary focus on media–politics linkages
4	<i>Political Psychology</i>	6	Flagship outlet for emotion- and cognition-based analyses of politics
5	<i>Public Opinion Quarterly</i>	5	Long-running journal of survey & opinion methodology
6	<i>International Journal of Public Opinion Research</i>	4	WAPOR-sponsored journal on opinion formation & polling
7	<i>Electoral Studies</i>	3	Specialist venue for election and voting research worldwide

Table 1. Most Productive Journals

Three specialized communication journals account for over 75% of the literature. Political Communication, recognized for its robust cadre of methodological rigor and theoretical breadth, has featured the full range from Kinsey and Chaffee’s (1996) treatment of media use to recent leader-priming experiments by Takens et al. (2015). European Journal of Communication is another dominant outlet, having published both Bos and Brants’s (2014) in-depth longitudinal analysis and Maurer and Diehl’s (2020) cross-Atlantic Twitter ethnography. Meanwhile, the International Journal of Press/Politics bridges disciplines by hosting comparative leadership research, such as Aaldering et al. (2018) and Dawson (2024), providing a rare interface between media studies and political science. Political Psychology and Public Opinion Quarterly round out the top journals, with the former focusing on emotion- and information-based mechanisms (Redlawsk, 2004) and the latter advancing field experiments using digital trace data (Munzert et al., 2020).

This journal's concentration reflects the field's institutional identity, but it also implies insularity from the broader discourse of general political science.

3.3. Most Prolific Publications

Highlighting the most cited and methodologically influential articles helps trace the intellectual genealogy of the field and identify benchmarking touchstones that subsequent studies build upon. (see Table 2)

Article (first author, year)	Approx. Google Scholar citations*
Erikson & Wlezien, 1999	700+
Redlawsk, 2004	650+
Domke et al., 2000	640+
Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2001	520+
Carlson 2001	500+
Bos, Van der Brug & De Vreese, 2011	440+
Stolwijk et al., 2017	220+
Gerstlé & Nai, 2019	210+
Dolezal et al., 2016	190+
Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020	160+

Table 2. Most Prolific Publications

Several studies stand as cornerstones for campaign effects literature. Erikson and Wlezien's (1999) polling dynamics study remains the benchmark for modeling bandwagon effects in public opinion. Redlawsk's (2004) innovative process-tracing work pioneered digital-trace strategies by isolating voters' real-time information search behaviors. Carlson's cross-cultural examination of gendered political advertising (2001) is still a norm-setting example for gendered mediation research, while Kleinnijenhuis et al. (2001) pioneered comparative coverage analysis of issue versus personality in media systems. In more recent scholarship, Dolezal, Enns-Jedenastik, and Müller's (2016) study of negativity spirals in Austrian multiparty contests empirically confirmed retaliatory logic under proportional representation. Gerstlé and Nai's (2019) extensive forty-country study of populist rhetoric and its effects offers an unmatched global benchmark for future research.

4. TCM Framework

4.1. Theory

A thorough analysis of the theoretical perspectives anchors the study within established academic discourse. By mapping the frameworks that have guided previous research and identifying where they fall short, the conceptual rigor of the article is sharpened, identifying unmet theoretical needs and guiding innovative contributions. Table 3 summarizes the prevalent theoretical perspectives in the studies.

Theoretical Perspectives	Core premise	Relevance to campaigns & voting	Representative studies
<i>Agenda-setting & Priming</i>	Media increase issue salience and weight specific considerations in vote choice.	Explains how visibility of leaders/ issues triggers switching.	Aaldering et al., 2018; Takens et al., 2015; Geers & Bos, 2017
<i>Populist Communication</i>	Anti-elite, people-centrism, emotional language shape mobilisation.	Accounts for user engagement and vote intention online/ offline.	Gerstlé & Nai, 2019; Hameleers et al., 2021
<i>Negative Campaigning</i>	Attacks signal policy differences but risk backlash.	Predicts retaliation patterns and emotional reactions.	Banda, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016; Song et al., 2019
<i>Affective Intelligence</i>	Anxiety & enthusiasm mediate information processing.	Emotion explains bandwagon, learning and polarisation.	Stolwijk et al., 2017; Neyazi & Kuru, 2024
<i>Poll/Bandwagon Effects</i>	Lead indicators nudge strategic voters.	Integrates polling cycles with enthusiasm/anger pathways.	Erikson & Wlezien, 1999; Daoust & Mongrain, 2023; Dawson, 2024
<i>Gendered Mediation</i>	Media frames differ by candidate sex and intersectional identity.	Shapes candidate viability, stereotype activation.	Carlson, 2001; Ross et al., 2013; Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020; Ward, 2017
<i>Digital Information Processing</i>	Cognitive off-loading and VAAs affect knowledge and turnout.	Addresses algorithmic curation, micro-targeting, e-guides.	Munzert et al., 2020; Kleinberg & Lau, 2021; Gahn, 2024.

Table 3. Theoretical Landscape

Understanding each theoretical framework in depth is essential because it sharpens our explanations of how electoral campaigns influence voter behavior, reveals critical knowledge gaps, and points to areas where future research can have a high impact.

4.1.1. Agenda Setting and Priming

Agenda-setting and priming theories explain not only what topics appear in public discourse but also how they shape voters’ judgment and decision criteria (McCombs & Shaw, 1993). By analyzing these theories, this study can reveal how campaign communications direct attention to specific issues, which in turn alter the factors voters use when evaluating candidates. This deepens insight into the temporal dynamics of campaigns, especially in today’s high-velocity news and social media flows. Longitudinal Dutch panel-content work shows that sustained newspaper attention to unemployment and purchasing power systematically shifts late-deciders toward parties emphasising those topics, confirming the “weight-change” version of priming (Geers & Bos, 2017). Leader-priming studies of the 2010 Dutch campaign likewise find that intense coverage of party chairs re-weights leader images in voters’ utility functions rather than teaching new facts (Takens et al., 2015). Comparable estimates for first-past-the-post or compulsory-voting systems—and feeds curated by social-media algorithms—are still missing, leaving us unable to tell whether salience logic travels across electoral rules or digital architectures.

4.1.2. Populist Communication

Populist rhetoric—anchored in anti-elite and people-centric language—mobilizes affective and identity-based responses (Hameleers et al., 2021). Examining this framework illuminates how emotional appeals bypass rational evaluation, especially when combined with platform amplification. This gains importance given the exponential reach of algorithmically curated content, which intensifies micro-targeted populist messaging. A 33-country content analysis reports that anti-elite and moralised language reliably boosts both media visibility and vote share, especially in low-competition presidential contests (Gerstlé & Nai, 2019). A decade-long Dutch time series reveals that populist rhetoric ebbs and flows in tandem with cycles of asylum salience and economic insecurity (Bos & Brants, 2014). Yet current designs treat populism as a fixed candidate trait; almost no study tracks how campaigns micro-target latent populist cues at niche segments that remain invisible to journalists or fact-checkers.

4.1.3. Negative Campaigning

Negative campaigning theory posits that attack ads serve as strategic signals to voters but may provoke backlash, especially in systems with multiple parties (Song et al., 2019). Dissecting this theory helps us understand the calculated trade-offs campaigns make between mobilizing their base and antagonizing others. It also raises fresh questions about how negativity cascades across media platforms in ways that earlier U.S.-centric models could not anticipate (Banda, 2014). U.S. laboratory experiments confirm voters' negativity bias, while an Austrian time-series shows that proportional systems do not inoculate parties against retaliatory spirals (Dolezal et al., 2016). Network analyses of 2017 European races reveal that attacks cluster inside ideologically adjacent “echo corridors,” amplifying in-party identity cues (Banda, 2014). Cross-platform ecologies—e.g., how a TikTok attack migrates to legacy TV—remain uncharted, as do patterns in hybrid regimes where investigative journalism is high-risk.

4.1.4. Affective Intelligence

Affective intelligence theory posits that emotions, such as anxiety and enthusiasm, serve as crucial mediators between information exposure and voting decisions (Neyazi & Kuru, 2024). Integrating this theory is vital for unpacking whether campaign stimuli create emotional rather than purely cognitive effects—and how these affect whether voters follow poll trends or resist them. Multi-wave Dutch-U.S. panels find that anxiety dampens, whereas enthusiasm accelerates, the bandwagon effect, turning emotion into the on/off switch for poll influence (Stolwijk et al., 2017). A Turkish lab experiment replicates the finding but shows that moral anger—rather than anxiety—drives turnout when polls are perceived as biased (Dawson, 2024). Biometric data have yet to be synchronized with ecological exposure measures, leaving emotional micro-dynamics largely speculative.

4.1.5. Poll/Bandwagon Effects

The bandwagon theory posits that early leads in polling can trigger self-fulfilling voter momentum, provided the polls are perceived as credible (Rothschild & Malhotra, 2014). Assessing this model informs our study of how voter perceptions of legitimacy and bias moderate campaign effects, which is key to understanding strategies surrounding poll release timing and messaging (Daoust & Mongrain, 2023). The seminal U.S. time series remains the baseline for modelling poll shocks (Erikson & Wlezien, 1999). Still, conjoint evidence suggests that perceived methodological quality significantly influences whether polls persuade or polarize (Dawson, 2024).

4.1.6. Gendered Mediation

Research on gendered mediation reveals that media systems often privilege male candidates through increased visibility, selective framing, and perpetuation of stereotypes (Ross et al., 2013). This theory is crucial for exposing structural biases in campaign communication and media coverage, particularly when examining intersectional outcomes in new contexts. A meta-analysis of 70 elections documents persistent visibility gaps that disadvantage women in proportional systems (Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020). Earlier cross-cultural advertising work shows that female candidates adopt dual-strategy ads balancing warmth and competence cues to secure airtime (Carlson, 2001).

4.1.7. Digital Information Processing

The digital information processing theory examines how voters interact with online content and delegate memory to systems, rather than relying solely on their cognitive abilities (Gahn 2024). Including this perspective is crucial in a campaign era dominated by search engines, chatbots, and voter guidance apps. It helps trace how informational architecture shapes political knowledge, deliberation, and turnout behavior (Munzert et al., 2020). A field experiment demonstrates that “cognitive off-loading” via online voter guides can improve vote-choice quality when information is abundant (Kleinberg & Lau, 2021). Yet scholars know little about how algorithmic personalization shapes what gets offloaded, nor whether low-literacy electorates benefit comparably.

4.1.8. Gaps Regarding Theory

Understanding each theoretical framework not only strengthens our comprehension of electoral campaigns but also helps to identify pivotal research gaps that limit the generalizability and precision of current knowledge. While agenda-setting and priming theories have been extensively validated in multiparty systems, such as the Netherlands, their applicability to more polarized or structurally distinct systems (e.g., first-past-the-post, compulsory voting regimes, or digital-first electorates) remains underexplored. For instance, although priming effects have been observed in longitudinal studies, there is a lack of comparative research across varying electoral rules and media ecosystems, especially those governed by algorithmic content curation. This leaves a critical blind spot in understanding whether and how issue salience mechanisms generalize across contexts increasingly shaped by digital architectures. Similarly, while research on populist communication has identified its emotional potency and cyclical rise in tandem with external shocks, most studies treat populist rhetoric as a static candidate trait rather than a dynamic campaign strategy. Little is known about how campaigns micro-target populist cues to niche voter segments—especially via platforms and private channels not easily monitored by traditional media researchers. In the realm of negative campaigning, growing evidence challenges U.S.-centric assumptions about backlash, but still lacks fine-grained insights into how attack messaging diffuses across hybrid digital and traditional platforms or how these dynamics play out in fragile media environments. Affective intelligence theory likewise suffers from a technological gap: although experiments show that emotional cues modulate voter responsiveness, the absence of biometric or ecological tracking impedes our understanding of real-time emotional responses to campaign stimuli. These lacunae collectively signal the need for comparative, multimethod research that bridges digital, emotional, and structural dimensions of electoral behavior.

4.2. Context

Examining contexts helps determine where, when, and among whom research findings are applicable, thereby avoiding overgeneralization and enhancing external validity (Paul et al., 2017). Table 4 presents the contexts in which the reviewed studies focused.

Context (country/region)	No. of Studies
Western Europe (Netherlands, Germany, Austria, UK)	23
North America (USA, Canada)	9
Nordic & Benelux	6
Israel	1
India	1
Turkey	1
Cross-national/Global	5

Table 4. Contextual Coverage

Nearly half the papers investigate Western Europe, with the Netherlands, Germany, and Austria providing dense longitudinal media datasets (e.g., Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2001; Bos & Brants, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016). North American research comprises roughly one-fifth, including Henderson et al.'s (2010) study of thwarted primary voters and Kinsey & Chaffee's (1996) early work on presidential approval. Global-South democracies are virtually absent, save for Marmor-Lavie and Weimann's (2006) examination of emotional appeals in Israel and Neyazi & Kuru's (2024) Turkish poll-mobilization experiment. Contextual under-coverage limits external validity: theories developed in high-trust, high-media-freedom environments may falter when platform access is restricted, electoral institutions differ, or compulsory voting is in place. Moreover, complex diaspora electorates, multilingual media ecosystems, and campaigns under authoritarian pressure remain understudied terrains.

4.2.1. Gaps Regarding Context

Significant theoretical and empirical challenges arise in relation to campaign communication within multilingual polities. In countries such as Switzerland and South Africa, where electorates are linguistically segmented, no study in the current dataset replicates the longitudinal agenda-setting designs found in the Netherlands or Austria (Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2001; Bos & Brants, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016). Consequently, it remains unclear whether issue salience is communicated and interpreted uniformly or differently across language communities—a question that directly affects theories of priming and framing in plural media environments. The influences of diasporic media ecosystems are similarly underexplored. For example, Turkish emigrants in Germany and Filipino workers in the Gulf receive political messaging from both homeland social media and host-country broadcasters. Yet these transnational media experiences have not been captured in standardized sampling frames, leaving open questions about how cross-border exposure interacts with existing campaign effects such as populist rhetoric and negativity spill-over (Bos & Brants, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016). Without such investigations, theoretical assumptions made on the basis of single-country settings may not apply to electorates embedded in hybrid media contexts. Subnational campaigns, low-profile referenda, and national elections conducted under sudden platform restrictions (e.g., Pakistan's 2024 TikTok blackout) remain entirely outside the current research corpus. Institutional features such as compulsory voting, open-list proportional representation, and pre-election judicial injunctions influence campaign strategy and voter behaviour. However, causal leverage on how these electoral architectures condition persuasive communications is absent, meaning that key theoretical moderators remain untested.

4.3. Method

Methodological scrutiny reveals not just how research has been conducted, but how reliably its findings can be interpreted and reproduced (Öztürk et al., 2024). Figure 3 displays the methodologies employed in the reviewed studies.

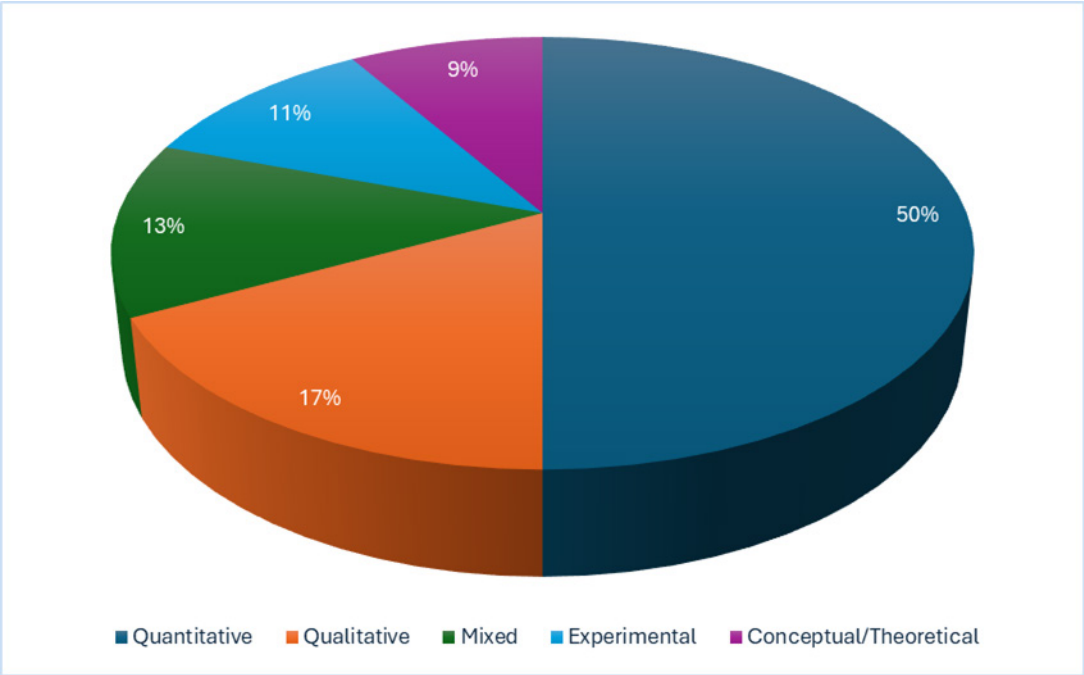


Figure 3. Methodological Approaches Adopted by Reviewed Studies. Source: Author’s own drawing.

The methodological profile of the 46 studies reviewed is tilted toward large-N, quantitative designs (23 studies; 50 %). These survey-panel, content-analytic, or meta-analytic works have been pivotal for documenting agenda-setting filters (Geers et al., 2017) and gender-visibility gaps (Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020). Their statistical power and replicability have produced robust effect-size benchmarks and enabled cumulative meta-inference. Yet the very features that make them powerful also narrow their lens: the heavy reliance on self-report survey items, dictionary-based text classifiers, and Western European sampling frames limits ecological validity in media systems where algorithmic curation, low trust, or multilingual discourse are the norm. Only 17 % of the corpus (8 studies) employs qualitative approaches—long-duration textual tracing (Bos & Brants, 2014) or interpretive media ethnography. These studies excel at unpacking rhetoric, symbolism, and path-dependent media–party relations, but their case-centric logic and small samples raise concerns about generalizability. Mixed methods work (6 studies; 13%) represents a promising but still underdeveloped bridge. Most of these designs follow a sequential explanatory logic in which qualitative insights merely illustrate quantitative findings rather than being fully integrated through joint display. Pure experiments comprise 11 % of the sample (5 studies). Landmark laboratory work and survey-embedded experiments manipulating poll cues have delivered the field’s strongest causal claims. Still, they remain skewed toward U.S. single-member-district contexts and convenience online panels. Conceptual and theoretical contributions (4 studies; 9%)—notably, the classic agenda-setting syntheses show intellectual growth, but few of these pieces address the digital aspects that now shape exposure and attention.

4.3.1. Gaps Regarding Method

In the reviewed studies, no quantitative panel synchronizes real-time physiological data (e.g., galvanic skin response, heart-rate variability) with ecological media exposure, and only a handful of mixed-method projects integrate server-side logs, browser histories, or platform APIs. This leaves emotion-driven theories—such as affective intelligence—largely untested under naturalistic conditions. Over two-thirds of quantitative and experimental evidence comes from Western Europe or the United States. Qualitative case studies add some diversity, but comparative coverage of hybrid regimes,

compulsory-voting systems, and digital-first electorates remains thin. Furthermore, negative-campaigning and populist-messaging mechanisms have been identified within single channels (such as TV ads, newspapers, or Twitter). Yet, the cascade of the same attack across TikTok, encrypted messaging apps, and legacy media remains methodologically elusive. Additionally, multi-site data linkage and temporal network models are rare. Moreover, existing mixed-method studies seldom move beyond parallel analyses. Little work employs concurrent triangulation, which would allow qualitative insights to update quantitative priors in real-time. Lastly, while seminal agenda-setting syntheses remain widely cited, there is a dearth of conceptual work theorising algorithmic salience, cognitive off-loading, and AI-mediated voter guidance. Without such models, empirical tests risk chasing moving technological targets with outdated theoretical lenses.

5. Agenda for Future Research

5.1. Theory

Future research in electoral campaign studies should aim to broaden the theoretical and empirical scope of the field by addressing gaps in current knowledge. Comparative studies that test the limits of key campaign theories in different contexts are a priority. For example, while priming and agenda-setting effects are well-studied in multiparty European systems, there's a lack of research on whether these mechanisms work the same way under majoritarian rules, compulsory voting, or in digital-first democracies where algorithmic feeds shape what people see. Studies should investigate how issue emphasis and leader-focused priming play out in environments with varying levels of media freedom, platform regulation, and electoral competitiveness. Populist communication is also under-researched as a targeted campaign strategy, especially in its micro-targeted, data-driven forms. Future work should examine how populist cues are selectively activated for niche audiences across different platforms and whether these tactics go unnoticed by traditional gatekeepers like journalists or fact-checkers. Furthermore, future research should delve deeper into the emotional and digital aspects of campaigning that current studies only partially address. While affective intelligence theory shows that emotions influence the impact of polls and campaign stimuli, empirical work often lacks the real-time or physiological data needed to capture these emotional shifts outside the lab. Bridging this gap requires using biometric tools and digital tracking to observe emotional reactions as they unfold in natural campaign settings. In the realm of negative campaigning, future studies should explore how attack content spreads across hybrid media spaces—e.g., how a negative TikTok post resonates through TV news, WhatsApp groups, or meme pages—and how these diffusion patterns vary across different electoral and media systems. Ultimately, the cognitive offloading literature would benefit from a closer examination of how algorithmic personalization affects the quality and equity of voter guidance, particularly in contexts with low literacy or high polarization. These lines of inquiry are crucial for developing a more nuanced, realistic understanding of how modern campaigns influence voter behavior.

5.2. Context

Longitudinal panel-content linkage studies should be conducted in multilingual democracies such as Switzerland and South Africa. By coding issues by language in media outputs and matching them to in-language surveys, it's possible to test whether agenda-setting coefficients vary across language groups. Existing European models (e.g., Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2001) can be replicated using multilingual coders to determine whether linguistic segmentation fractures or unifies campaign influence. Furthermore, quasi-experimental diary studies and context-sensitive survey panels are recommended for migrant communities, such as Turks in Germany or Filipinos in the Middle East, to quantify how dual media diets alter campaign salience and emotional response. This methodology will test whether populist framing,

negativity strategies, or leader-priming effects observed domestically (Bos & Brants, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016) are reduced or amplified in transnational settings, thereby extending theoretical models into diasporic contexts. Additionally, campaign effects should be studied in settings with mandatory voting (e.g., Australian state elections), open-list systems (e.g., Italian or Brazilian municipal races), and during elections held after judicial injunctions or platform outages. Interrupted time-series designs and rollout randomization of candidate messages offer empirical leverage to isolate the influence of institutional variables on negativity, populism, and algorithmic targeting effects—areas that current models have yet to fully explore.

5.3. Method

Future studies should combine large-scale behavioral data with real-time psychophysiological indicators to test theories about emotions under real-life exposure conditions. By partnering with news apps, social media platforms, and voter guidance tools, researchers can get click-stream logs, server-side impression data, and algorithmic feed configurations. Meanwhile, wearable sensors like wristband galvanic skin response and smartphone-embedded photoplethysmography can capture in-the-moment emotional arousal. By embedding randomized message treatments in these everyday environments and synchronizing data and biometric streams with ongoing surveys, researchers can determine whether emotions like anxiety, anger, or enthusiasm truly influence how people respond to messages outside the lab. Furthermore, ethical-by-design protocols (differential privacy, federated analytics) are essential to safeguard participants and secure platform cooperation. Moreover, future research should aim to correct the Western Europe–North America bias by using multi-country field experiments and coordinated open panels in various settings, including compulsory-voting, majoritarian, hybrid-regime, and digital-first systems. Partnering with groups like the Comparative Campaign Dynamics Project or regional survey networks (e.g., Afrobarometer, LAPOP) can provide standardized sampling methods and cost-sharing. Research questions should specifically explore how institutional rules (e.g., vote-seat disparity), media freedom, and internet access influence the impact of agenda-setting, priming, and negative campaigning. When randomization isn't possible, quasi-experimental designs—such as synthetic controls at the constituency or platform-algorithm level—can offer a way to make causal inferences. Moreover, negative and populist cues spread rapidly across platforms like TikTok, encrypted groups, and traditional broadcast media within hours. Researchers should collect and analyze these cascades by building time-stamped multimodal databases (video, image, text) linked through hash-matching and cross-posting metadata. By using dynamic network models and sequence analysis, they can determine whether message trajectories vary by platform features and audience demographics. When combined with audience-level exposure diaries or passive metering panels, this will help clarify how diffusion patterns affect individual attitudes and voting behavior. Additionally, instead of using qualitative components as an afterthought, future mixed-method studies should use concurrent or iterative designs where ethnographic observations or in-depth interviews inform and are updated by Bayesian multilevel models or machine-learning classifiers. By combining qualitative codes and quantitative estimates in joint displays, researchers can identify discrepancies early on and adjust their data collection approach. Methodological handbooks now offer templates for synthesizing Bayesian evidence and applying them to campaign communication will allow for ongoing learning while honoring the strengths of each approach. Conceptual scholarship needs to keep pace with technological advancements. To do this, agenda-setting and priming models must be reworked to account for algorithmic gatekeepers, cognitive off-loading, and AI-generated content. Formal theories that explain how recommender systems prioritize issue attributes—or how large-language models influence the information supply as “second-order elites”—will provide empirical research with clearer causal mechanisms to investigate. This process of theory development should be iterative, blending normative insights from political philosophy with empirical patterns uncovered through the digital-trace studies mentioned earlier.

5.4. Theoretical Implications

Research on agenda-setting and priming remains strong in Western European systems with many choices, where long-term data shows that consistent media coverage of leaders and key issues affects how people vote late in the election cycle (Kleinnijenhuis et al., 2001; Bos & Brants, 2014; Geers & Bos, 2017). However, there is a lack of similar data on how people vote in systems with different electoral rules, such as those with a single winner or mandatory voting, making it unclear whether these effects apply to all voting systems. Future studies on this topic should avoid biased conclusions by incorporating factors such as ballot structure and voter turnout rules into their models. Large-scale comparative studies have demonstrated that anti-elite rhetoric and strategic negativity can enhance news visibility and increase vote shares (Dolezal et al., 2016; Gerstlé & Nai, 2019). However, the effectiveness of such frames is unclear when information controls tighten under authoritarian constraints or platform blackouts. This suggests that the impact of populist and negative appeals may reverse when media freedom is restricted. To address this, theories of campaign tone need to incorporate measures of media freedom and the level of algorithmic transparency. Emotion plays a crucial role in persuasion: anxiety can dampen, while enthusiasm can amplify, as seen in poll-driven bandwagons, as observed in Dutch panel studies (Stolwijk et al., 2017). On the other hand, moral anger can boost turnout when people doubt the credibility of polls, as seen in studies on Turkey (Neyazi & Kuru, 2024). However, few studies use biometric or passive-sensor data, and current emotion dictionaries mostly only cover English. Combining psychophysiological measures with sentiment analysis across multiple languages could significantly enhance our understanding of how emotions influence decision-making. Research has shown that women receive less attention from campaigns in proportional systems (Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020), while studies on cross-cultural advertising have found that people use different strategies to present themselves based on their gender (Carlson, 2001). However, visual framing and biases related to queer intersectional identities are largely unmeasured, highlighting a pressing need to expand research on gendered mediation to include image analytics and broader identity categories. Lastly, studies have found that voter guides can enhance decision-making quality in elections with a lot of information by alleviating some of the cognitive load on voters (Kleinberg & Lau, 2021); however, concepts like algorithmic gatekeeping and multilingual information architectures are missing from the discussion. Therefore, online information search should be viewed as a process that's jointly shaped by platform design, language barriers, and regulatory frameworks.

5.5. Practical Implications

Understanding the implications of this study is crucial for policymakers, platform operators, journalists, and campaign practitioners as they navigate the evolving landscape of campaign communication and democratic accountability.

For campaign strategists and political consultants, the value of context-aware messaging is clear. While negative and populist appeals may gain visibility and mobilization in Western European and North American settings (Bos & Brants, 2014; Dolezal et al., 2016), these strategies can backfire in environments with limited media freedom or low trust in institutions. To ensure their campaign tactics align with—and respect—the voices of their intended audiences, practitioners should conduct multimodal audits that evaluate not only the message content but also the platform's targeting algorithms and regulatory environment. Political leaders and party elites should increase transparency in their campaign operations. The growing use of “dark ads”—targeted content that vanishes from public view—threatens democratic accountability and public trust. Implementing internal disclosure protocols for these ads and third-party vendors can bring practices in line with upcoming regulations like the Honest Ads Act, which requires transparency in online political ads and may close loopholes that allow anonymous digital messaging. Platform operators and ad-tech firms also have a crucial role in building a democratic infrastructure. By using transparent ad libraries—like those from Facebook and Meta—people can scrutinize political ads, including targeting details, spending, and timeframes. To

build trust while supporting linguistic and diasporic complexities, platforms should expand their APIs with metadata that indicates language targeting and diaspora outreach, especially in EU jurisdictions undergoing regulatory changes. Journalists and newsroom editors can use these tools to hold better campaigns accountable. Automated dashboards that track ad visibility, gender representation, and targeting topics across platforms can help bring underrepresented voices to light and counteract algorithmic bias. Given the ongoing disparities in representation—especially for women and minority candidates—these media audits serve both professional and ethical purposes (Carlson, 2001; Van der Pas & Aaldering, 2020). To address these new dynamics, regulators and electoral commissions must update their legal frameworks. Bipartisan initiatives, such as the Honest Ads Act, require digital ads to have the same transparency standards as broadcast ads, including disclaimers, purchaser information, and targeting data (Klobuchar, Graham & Warner, 2023). Platforms can also adopt best practices by keeping long-term ad archives and using algorithmic checks to reduce echo-chamber effects. Additionally, standardized poll blackout windows—required in some areas—can help reduce the impact of emotionally charged bandwagon effects (Stolwijk et al., 2017; Neyazi & Kuru, 2024). By aligning operational best practices with empirical insights, campaign actors, platforms, media professionals, and regulators can create systems that promote democratic health, increase transparency, and respect the global diversity of electoral environments.

5.6. Limitations

Like other literature reviews, this one has its limitations. Initially, research was sourced from the Web of Science (WoS) database, which offers broad coverage of many leading journals. However, there may be relevant studies from other databases that we have not included. Future researchers should explore databases such as Scopus, ScienceDirect, EBSCO, and JSTOR to expand the review's scope and ensure that there are no duplicate entries. A thorough search strategy centered on relevant keywords was employed; however, it may have missed some studies if their keywords, titles, or abstracts didn't include the selected terms. Future researchers should conduct their own searches to identify significant papers for screening and eligibility. Expert peer reviews could not be employed to refine our search due to time constraints. Future research could be improved by incorporating a review process to enhance the robustness of its results. This study examined 46 peer-reviewed studies, making a notable contribution to the research areas. These studies primarily drew on perspectives from relevant fields, resulting in discussions that were limited to a particular research domain. Future research could broaden its scope to enrich discussions on relevant subjects by partnering with scholars from diverse research fields.

6. Conclusion

This study conducted a systematic literature review of 46 peer-reviewed studies examining the relationship between electoral campaigns and voter behavior within the TCM (Theory-Context-Method) framework. The study mapped the prevalence and robustness of six theoretical paradigms—agenda-setting/priming, populist communication, negative campaigning, affective intelligence, poll/bandwagon effects, and gendered mediation—highlighting both their empirical strengths and their vulnerabilities across different institutional, linguistic, and technological contexts. The analysis revealed that while Western European and North American democracies are well-represented, significant gaps persist in Global-South polities, diasporic electorates, multilingual media systems, and authoritarian or platform-restricted environments. Methodological approaches were similarly uneven: rich content–survey panels coexist alongside innovative digital-trace experiments, yet biometric validation, encrypted-channel analysis, and multilingual NLP tools remain underutilized. The convergence of these findings highlights the urgent need for more context-calibrated,

institutionally grounded, and methodologically plural research to ensure that theoretical models remain robust in an increasingly globalized democratic landscape.

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